

Seasonal Arthritis Guide: Managing Symptoms Through the UK Y

Each season brings different challenges for arthritis. Discover how to adapt your routine month by month for year-round comfort.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Seasonal Arthritis Guide for the UK



Openly licensed image via Openverse

British weather is famously unpredictable — and for people with arthritis, those changes can mean the difference between a good day and a painful one. Here is how to stay ahead of your symptoms throughout the year.

Spring (March–May)

****The good:**** Rising temperatures and longer days encourage outdoor activity. Vitamin D levels begin to recover after winter.

****The challenge:**** Fluctuating temperatures and barometric pressure can trigger flare-ups. Hay fever medications (antihistamines) can interact with some arthritis drugs.



Openly licensed image via Openverse

****Tips:**** - Layer clothing so you can adjust to temperature swings - Start a gentle walking programme as days lengthen — aim for 20 minutes daily - Get your vitamin D levels checked; many UK adults remain deficient even in spring - Garden in short bursts (20-minute sessions) using ergonomic tools with padded grips

Summer (June–August)

****The good:**** Warmth generally eases stiffness. This is when most people with arthritis report feeling their best.

****The challenge:**** Heat and humidity can cause swelling. Dehydration worsens joint lubrication.



Openly licensed image via Openverse

****Tips:**** - Stay hydrated — aim for 2 litres daily, more in hot weather - Exercise early morning or evening to avoid peak heat - Use cooling gel packs for swollen joints - Wear supportive sandals (Birkenstock, FitFlop) rather than flat flip-flops - Apply SPF 30+ — some arthritis

medications (methotrexate, hydroxychloroquine) increase sun sensitivity

Autumn (September–November)

The good: Moderate temperatures are comfortable for most. Seasonal produce (squash, berries, leafy greens) supports an anti-inflammatory diet.

The challenge: Dropping temperatures and increasing dampness. Reduced daylight can affect mood.

Tips: - Transition to warmer layers; invest in merino wool base layers that trap heat without bulk - Boost omega-3 intake with seasonal oily fish (mackerel, sardines) - Consider a SAD lamp (10,000 lux) to maintain mood as daylight hours shrink - Get your flu jab — arthritis patients on immunosuppressants are at higher risk

Winter (December–February)

The good: The festive season offers social connection, which supports mental health.

The challenge: Cold is the number one weather complaint among arthritis patients. Morning stiffness can last significantly longer.

Tips: - Use an electric blanket or heated mattress pad to warm joints before getting up - Run a warm shower for 5–10 minutes each morning to ease stiffness - Keep hands warm with thermal gloves; consider heated gloves for severe Raynaud's - Maintain exercise indoors — online yoga classes, stationary cycling, or swimming in heated pools - Eat warming, anti-inflammatory foods: turmeric golden milk, ginger soups, slow-cooked stews with plenty of vegetables

Year-Round Essentials

- **Track your symptoms:** Apps like Cloudy with a Chance of Pain (developed by the University of Manchester) help identify your personal weather triggers
- **Consistent medication:** Don't skip doses because you feel good — consistency prevents flare-ups
- **Regular check-ups:** See your rheumatologist or GP at least annually

Key Takeaway

Understanding how seasons affect your arthritis gives you the power to prepare, not just react. Small adjustments each quarter can make a dramatic difference to your quality of life.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about seasonal arthritis guide: managing symptoms through the uk y?

Short answer: Managing arthritis symptoms year-round involves adapting to seasonal changes. In spring and autumn, layer clothing to combat fluctuating temperatures. Stay hydrated in summer, aiming for 2 litres daily, and protect sun-sensitive skin. To ease winter stiffness, use heated blankets and warm showers. Consistent medication and tracking symptoms are important year-round to pre-empt flare-ups.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk